provide for a temporary shelter from German nationalism. At the same time, Slovenians entered a new geopolitical context, the Balkans. There was little common history and memory to share, except pan-Slavic myths. Not surprisingly, therefore, the concept of the Yugoslav nation never really took off.

In foreign relations, the new kingdom was primarily concerned about its relations with the immediate neighbours of the Serbs, above all with Bulgaria. (There was even talk of a merger with Bulgaria.) There was not enough incentive left to deal with the territorial claims of Italy and Austria. Indeed, the western part of what is today Slovenia was after World War I swiftly occupied by Italy, while in the Slovenian-populated Carinthia (now a province in Austria) a plebiscite was held. There, the prospect of Serbian dominance convinced many ethnic Slovenians to opt for Austria. But after the area did become a part of the new republic, previous Austrian assurances of cultural autonomy for ethnic Slovenians in Carinthia were forgotten and, with the advent of Nazism, Slovenians there became its first target, but also Austria's foremost resistance. Despite that not even post-WW II Austria managed to respect minority rights in full. Successive regional Carinthian and federal Austrian governments failed to fulfil their international obligations, above all to codify the use of Slovenian language. In 1972, media, police and authorities stood idle watching nationalist mobs destroying bilingual road signs, erected in accordance with the Austrian State Treaty. Forty years later a constitutional act bypassed the Treaty, securing only a fraction of the original number of bilingual names of places. Although the atmosphere has improved now that communist Yugoslavia no longer exists, in Carinthia the minority still faces prejudices and an unwillingness to acknowledge it publicly. Interestingly this receives little attention in the European media, perhaps because such attitudes are difficult to reconcile with the otherwise positive international image of Austria. Chauvinists are usually sought elsewhere – in Eastern Europe. Not even a very noble apology, issued in Slovenian in 2020, a century after those events, by the President of Austria Mr Van der Bellen, has changed much.

Elsewhere, in relations with Italy, it was the Slovenian President Pahor and his Italian counterpart Mattarella who showed their courage. In 2020, on the centenary of the Fascist arson of the landmark Slovenian cultural centre in Triest/Trst, depicted later by the famous writer Boris Pahor (no